

— TWENTY-FIVE HONEST NOTES FROM THE OTHER SIDE

25 hot takes *about getting* sober *yes, really.*

The things people most need to hear are usually the things nobody thinks to say. So here they are, written plainly.

BY ALEXIS ANTONELLI

Recovery support specialist turned sober adventurer + freelancer making \$10k/month

BEFORE WE START

Four years in recovery spaces taught me what *really* helps.

I spent four years working in clinical recovery as a support specialist, a sober house manager, an ABA therapist, and a case manager. Then I got sober myself, and learned that the textbook version leaves out almost everything that matters.

This is what I tell people when they are starting out. It is also what I tell people who are a year in and quietly wondering why it still feels this hard. (If that's you, go research Post Acute Withdrawal Syndrome when you finish this. It explains a lot.)

None of this asks you to label yourself, join anything, or believe in a particular framework. It is just honest. Take what fits and leave the rest.

Alexis

ALEXIS ANTONELLI · WRITING FROM CHIANG MAI

WHAT'S INSIDE

Six chapters, *twenty-five truths*.

02	The Fog Lifts	YOUR BRAIN · 4 NOTES
03	The Long Middle	TIME & IDENTITY · 5 NOTES
04	The People Around You	RELATIONSHIPS · 4 NOTES
05	The Practice	WHAT HELPS MOST · 6 NOTES
06	The Payoff	WHY IT'S WORTH IT · 2 NOTES

01

The First *Two Weeks*

Nobody warns you that the start is physical. Your body has been doing quiet work for a long time, and now it gets to heal out loud.

01

The first two weeks are physical, and they're *rough*.

Most people brace for the emotional weight. It is the physical detox that catches you off guard, especially coming off something like marijuana.

Even if your use wasn't daily, you might not sleep, your body might shake, and your appetite might go unpredictable for longer than feels reasonable. All of it is normal. It is tissue-level healing.

“be gentler with your body than you think you need to be.”

02

Sleep gets strange before it gets *good*.

Alcohol wrecks your sleep architecture even when it feels like it's helping you drift off. So in early sobriety your sleep changes a lot, and sometimes it gets worse before it gets better, which is maddening when you expected sobriety to fix it overnight.

Most people report genuinely good sleep, often for the first time in years, somewhere around months three to six. When it lands, it is one of the most noticeable gifts of the whole process.

03

Cravings have a ceiling, even when they *don't feel like it*.

A craving has a physical arc. If you can ride out the first ten or fifteen minutes without acting on it, the intensity almost always drops.

This is why urge surfing, which sounds ridiculous the first time you hear it, works when you try it. Once you know a craving has a ceiling, your whole relationship to it changes.

“it will pass. it always passes. set a timer if you have to.”

04

Your body will change, sometimes in *surprising directions*.

Some people lose weight when they stop drinking and some people gain it, because your relationship with food, appetite, and reward shifts in ways that aren't linear.

Your body is recalibrating from the inside out. Whichever direction the outside changes go, things tend to stabilize around the six to twelve month mark.

*The fog isn't who you are.
It's your brain healing.*

ON THE FIRST THREE MONTHS

02

The Fog *Lifts*

Your mind comes back slowly, then all at once. What you feel in the meantime is structural, not a verdict on your character.

05

Your brain will not feel like yours *for a while.*

Alcohol affects the prefrontal cortex, the amygdala, and the dopamine system, and healing those structures takes months rather than days. So the fog and the emotional instability of early sobriety are neurological, not personal failings.

Most people start feeling more like themselves around the three to six month mark, and it keeps improving from there. Sometimes it takes longer, depending on use.

“cultivate real empathy for yourself, and build anchor habits.”

06

The "pink cloud" is real, and *it ends*.

A lot of people hit a stretch of early sobriety where everything feels clear and euphoric and possible, and staying sober feels easy. That feeling is real. It is also temporary.

When it lifts, usually around three to six months, it can feel like something has gone wrong. What's really happening is that you're stepping into the real, long-term work.

07

Your emotions come back at *full volume*.

If you were using alcohol to manage anxiety, sadness, or numbness, those feelings don't disappear when you stop. They return at their original intensity, sometimes with a few months of backlog attached.

This is one of the biggest reasons early sobriety is easier with professional support. Those emotions are real, and they need somewhere to go.

08

The clarity is going to *surprise you*.

People describe sober thinking as sharper, faster, and quieter all at once. The first time you handle something that used to require a drink, and you realize you got through it completely fine, is a specific kind of moment.

It repeats. It compounds. It is genuinely hard to picture from where you're standing right now.

"this is how confidence grows. one handled moment at a time."

03

The Long *Middle*

The early milestones get the applause. The quieter middle is where the real life gets built, and where most people are surprised to find themselves.

09

Year two is often harder than *year one*.

In year one you have novelty, more active support, and the momentum of having made a big change. Then year two arrives quieter, and the absence of alcohol has to be filled with something real.

That is where a lot of people struggle. If you're in year two and feeling lost, you are not regressing and you are not alone.

10

Boredom is a bigger trigger than *stress*.

Everyone expects stress to be the main driver, and stress matters, but boredom takes more people out because it is harder to name and easier to wave off as not a real problem.

When you feel the pull to drink for no clear reason, your brain is often just defaulting to the most familiar thing it knows to do with empty time. Fill the schedule. Try a lot of things.

“but leave room for silence too. some of the work only happens when you go inward. find your own balance.”

11

Your relationship with time changes *completely*.

Sobriety gives you your evenings back, then your mornings, and eventually your weekends. The sheer volume of time that opens up can feel overwhelming at first, before it starts to feel like the entire point.

People who stay sober for years consistently name the return of time as one of the most unexpected gifts of the whole thing.

12

Grief is a real part of *early sobriety*.

Getting sober means grieving the version of you that drank, the social life built around it, and sometimes the identity you built around being the one who could handle their alcohol.

That grief is legitimate, and not something to rush past. The people who let themselves feel it tend to build something sturdier on the other side. If you suppress it, it will resurface. I promise.

You don't have to call yourself *an alcoholic*.

Some people find the label useful because it hands them community and a framework. Some people find it builds a box that doesn't match their experience.

Neither position is wrong, as long as you stay sober. You get to decide which story about yourself helps you do that.

*The friendships that
survive are deeper than
anything built around
drinking.*

ON WHO STAYS

04

The People *Around You*

Sobriety reorganizes your relationships whether you ask it to or not. Some of that is loss. A lot of it is the start of something more honest.

14

Some friendships won't survive, and that *isn't all bad*.

Sobriety changes your tolerances and your priorities, and that makes some relationships feel incompatible. Grieving those is real and legitimate.

But a lot of people also find that the friendships which survive turn out deeper than anything they had before. The ones who leave when you get sober were mostly there for the drinking version of you, not for your values.

15

You will have to rebuild your *social identity*.

For a lot of people, drinking was woven into how they saw themselves socially. Sobriety asks you to work out who you are at a party, on a date, or with your family when alcohol isn't doing the talking.

It is awkward at first, and it gets easier with practice. Giving yourself full permission to be awkward while you figure it out speeds the whole thing up.

16

The people closest to you may *not celebrate it*.

Some people in your life benefited from your drinking, whether that was shared social cover or the quiet relief of feeling better about their own. When you stop, their reaction can run from indifferent to actively undermining.

That reaction belongs to them. Understanding it as theirs is easier to do in your head than in your heart, which is worth knowing before it happens.

“*this one can feel yucky. it is theirs to carry, not yours.*”

17

Your relationship with honesty *will shift.*

Drinking almost always involves some dishonesty, whether about how much you drank, how you're really doing, or who you are when you're not managing yourself chemically. Removing it forces a recalibration that feels uncomfortable before it feels like relief.

Most people find their tolerance for their own self-deception drops fast, which occasionally complicates relationships and mostly improves your life.

05

The Practice

None of this is about willpower. It is about a handful of small, unglamorous tools that work when you use them.

18

You will have to learn to *sit with yourself*.

Alcohol is one of the most effective tools humans have ever found for avoiding our own heads. Take it away, and you have to build a genuine tolerance for being present with no escape hatch.

That process is uncomfortable and necessary and not something you can shortcut. It gets meaningfully easier with time, but the first year is really about building that muscle.

19

HALT is annoying to remember and *worth it anyway.*

Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired. Those four states are behind a disproportionate share of relapse moments. They are not always dramatic. They just quietly lower your resistance in ways that are easy to miss while you're in them.

Checking those four things when a craving hits won't stop every craving, but it interrupts a lot of them.

"HALT. it sounds like a fridge magnet. it works like one too."

20

You will probably need *new hobbies.*

Drinking takes up a specific kind of time and social space, and when it's gone, a lot of people discover their hobbies were drinking-adjacent activities, not hobbies at all.

Finding things that genuinely engage you takes a few months of slightly uncomfortable experimenting. Most people land on at least one thing they never would have predicted, and it tends to matter to them a lot.

21

The reason you drank matters more than *you think*.

Sobriety is far more sustainable when you understand what alcohol was doing for you, whether that was managing anxiety, numbing loneliness, or getting through social situations. That underlying thing doesn't disappear when the drinking stops. (I wish it did.)

Addressing what was underneath is what separates the people who stay sober from the people who white-knuckle it until something breaks.

22

Meetings are a tool, *not a religion*.

AA and other twelve-step programs have helped millions of people, and they are also not the only path. You are allowed to keep the parts that work for you and leave the parts that don't.

What matters more than any single framework is having some structure and some community, because isolation in early sobriety is one of the most consistent relapse risks across every group I worked with. There is Refuge Recovery, Wellbriety and White Bison, SMART Recovery, A Course in Miracles.

“*don't yuck anyone's yum. go find your own jam.*”

Some days will be hard for *no clear reason*.

You'll get days where the craving is louder, where sobriety feels heavy and pointless, where you cannot point to a single trigger. Those days are part of the process, not evidence that something has gone wrong.

Having a plan for them, a person to call, a place to go, one specific thing to do, matters more than trying to prevent them from happening.

“for me, these turn out to be the best journal days.”

*A life without alcohol is
more interesting, not
less.*

THE PART NOBODY MENTIONS

06

The Payoff

Most sobriety messaging stops at the healing. Here is the part that doesn't get said enough: it gets genuinely good.

24

You can travel sober, and it's *better for it*.

This is the whole reason my page is called Sober Adventuring. Most people assume sobriety means giving up adventure, or that travel will be unbearable without a drink in hand.

Sober travel is sharper, cheaper, and far easier to remember. The discomfort of navigating social situations without alcohol fades faster than you'd expect when you're doing it somewhere new. The trips I've taken sober are the only ones I can describe to you in any detail.

Life gets genuinely *more interesting*.

Most sobriety messaging fixes on the hard parts and the healing. What doesn't get said often enough is that a life without alcohol is more interesting. The relationships get more real. The person you turn into is someone you're more likely to respect.

Getting sober is one of the hardest things most people will ever do, and over time it is also one of the most interesting decisions they ever make.

| *"for real. not the poster version."*

— WHEN YOU'RE READY

Want to talk it *through with someone?*

Twenty honest minutes to figure out where you really are and what the next steps could look like.

START HERE, FREE

The Clarity Call

A free twenty-minute call where we work out where you are in your sobriety, what's getting in the way, and what the next real step looks like.

[Book the free call →](#)

OR JUST LURK

The Telegram Group

Where people share what's really going on, not the polished version.

[Join the group →](#)

Sober *Adventuring.*

Building a life so interesting you don't want to escape it.

[SOBERADVENTURING.COM](#)

[BLOG](#)

[TAKE THE QUIZ](#)

[BOOK A CALL](#)